BELGRAVE CONSULTANCY

Project Costing
Discovery Checklist

FREE DISCOVERY TOOL

Check your cost visibility!

How to use this checklist

Use it before your ERP implementation workshops begin. Score each dimension honestly from 1 to 5. Complete it independently — managing director, finance lead, and at least one project manager — then compare your scores. Differences between finance and project scores are as informative as the scores themselves.

Total your score out of 35 and read your result at the end.

Scoring guide

1	Not in place / not considered
2	Early thinking only / significant gaps
3	Partially in place / work still needed
4	Largely in place / minor gaps remaining
5	Fully in place / confident and complete

1 Dimension 1 — Cost Visibility Level

Do you know at what level management needs to see cost and margin — per project, phase, vessel or asset, or work package?

Score	What it looks like	Your score
1	Not discussed. Cost is reported per department or as a total.	___ / 5
2	Some project reports exist, but people define the levels differently.	___ / 5
3	Project level is agreed. Lower levels — phase, asset, work package — are still undecided.	___ / 5
4	Levels are agreed and written down. Some reports are still compiled by hand.	___ / 5
5	The cost structure is agreed by management, finance and project managers, documented, and tested against real projects.	___ / 5

Why this matters: The system can only report at the level you design it for. Changing this after go-live means rebuilding cost codes and history. → See Chapter 8 of the guide.

2 Dimension 2 — Change Control

When the customer changes the design or scope, is it clear who decides whether you charge them for it — and how?

Score	What it looks like	Your score
1	No process. Changes are absorbed and discovered later.	___ / 5
2	Changes are discussed informally. Whether they are charged depends on who negotiates.	___ / 5
3	A change process exists on paper but is applied inconsistently.	___ / 5
4	Changes are logged and priced. Approval roles are defined but sometimes skipped under pressure.	___ / 5
5	Every change is logged, assessed for cost and price, approved by a named role, and linked to the project budget.	___ / 5

Why this matters: Unpriced changes are where project margin quietly disappears. An ERP system can track them — but only through a process you have decided on. → See Chapter 6 of the guide.

3 Dimension 3 — Committed Cost

Do you see cost when it is committed — an order placed, hours booked — or only when the invoice arrives?

Score	What it looks like	Your score
1	Cost only appears when invoices are processed.	___ / 5
2	Purchase orders exist for some spend. Much is still ordered by email or phone.	___ / 5
3	Most purchases have a purchase order, but not always linked to a project.	___ / 5
4	Purchase orders are linked to projects. Commitments are visible, with some delay.	___ / 5
5	All commitments are raised in the system against the right project and are visible the same day.	___ / 5

Why this matters: By the time the invoice arrives, the money is already spent. Committed cost is your early warning. → See Chapter 3 of the guide.

4 Dimension 4 — Labour Time

Are labour hours booked to the right project — promptly and accurately?

Score	What it looks like	Your score
1	Hours are not booked against projects.	___ / 5
2	Hours are booked weekly or monthly, largely from memory.	___ / 5
3	Hours are booked to projects, but not to phases or tasks. Corrections are common.	___ / 5
4	Hours are booked daily to project and phase, with occasional catch-up bookings.	___ / 5
5	Hours are booked daily at the agreed level and reviewed weekly by the project manager.	___ / 5

Why this matters: In engineering businesses, labour is often the largest and least visible cost. Late or approximate booking turns every margin report into a guess. → See Chapter 13 of the guide.

5 Dimension 5 — Cost Code Structure

Is your project cost code structure coherent, consistent and fit for how the business works today?

Score	What it looks like	Your score
1	Codes have grown piece by piece. Nobody owns them.	___ / 5
2	A structure exists, but codes are duplicated, obsolete, or used differently by different teams.	___ / 5
3	The structure is broadly understood. Known clean-up is still needed.	___ / 5
4	The structure has been reviewed recently and a clean-up plan is in place.	___ / 5
5	The structure is confirmed or redesigned for where the business is going, owned by a named person, and ready to migrate.	___ / 5

Why this matters: A new system built on an old cost code structure inherits its problems. Migration is the best moment you will get to fix it. → See Chapter 9 of the guide.

6 Dimension 6 — Forecast to Complete

Does each project have an up-to-date forecast of cost to complete — not just cost to date?

Score	What it looks like	Your score
1	Only actual cost to date is known.	___ / 5
2	A forecast is made at the start of the project and rarely updated.	___ / 5
3	Project managers update forecasts monthly in their own spreadsheets.	___ / 5
4	Forecasts are updated regularly and reviewed, but outside the main system.	___ / 5
5	Cost to complete and expected margin are updated in a regular project review and agreed with finance.	___ / 5

Why this matters: Cost to date tells you what happened. Cost to complete tells you whether the project will still make money. → See Chapter 8 of the guide.

7 Dimension 7 — Ownership and Action

Is it clear who acts when a project's margin starts to move — and how quickly?

Score	What it looks like	Your score
1	Margin problems surface at month-end or project close. Nobody owns them.	___ / 5
2	Finance flags problems. Project managers are not expected to act on cost.	___ / 5
3	Project managers own cost informally. Escalation is unclear.	___ / 5
4	Ownership is defined and margin is reviewed monthly.	___ / 5
5	Project managers own margin, review it at least every two weeks, and know the point at which they escalate.	___ / 5

Why this matters: Visibility without ownership is just a better report. Someone has to act on it. → See Chapter 6 of the guide.

Your total score across all 7 dimensions:	**___ / 35**

What your score means

29–35	**Ready to configure** Your foundations are solid. Share this checklist with your implementation partner as input for the design workshops.
20–28	**Define first** Good progress, but gaps remain. Identify your lowest-scoring dimensions and close them before the workshops start.
12–19	**Significant work needed** The system would be configured around assumptions. The work is mostly internal — and far cheaper now than after go-live.
Below 12	**Stop and map** Map how your projects actually make and lose money before you discuss configuration with any partner.

Want the complete framework?

The Software Is Not the Problem covers process mapping, requirements, data migration and go-live — written from the business side, not the vendor's.

Get the guide: belgraveconsultancy.lemonsqueezy.com

Free readiness scorecard: belgrave-consultancy.subscribepage.io

Belgrave Consultancy — *The Software Is Not the Problem*